



High spirits: While the home crowd undid the purpose of the 10 pm loudspeaker curfew with their thundering cheers, they also stood up in applause for a DC side that refused to give up. **SPORTZPICS** **Below:** A lady selling MI merchandise. **EMMANUAL YOGINI**

BRABOURNE BONHOMIE

The storied stadium in Mumbai, a relic of British India with its **timeless** Art Deco design and colonial club culture, was witness to Mumbai Indians' latest WPL triumph.

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In the last three years of its existence, several things have changed about the Women's Premier League (WPL). New venues have been added, the skill gap between teams have drastically reduced, and fresh talent has waltzed through the gates of the tournament to make the big stage their own. **But, at the same time, many elementary things have stayed the same, as observed by the Diary, fresh off what was easily the most competitive season of the league yet.**

"Oh, (I) finally see familiar faces... *tumhi log aate ho* (it's you guys only who come)," Royal Challengers Bengaluru captain Smriti Mandhana said, looking at the women's cricket reporters in the press conference room in Mumbai. This after underwhelming representation from

journalists in Vadodara and Lucknow.

In the four matches the Diary attended at the Brabourne Stadium in Mumbai, the venue didn't manage a full house until the final day. Given the home side, Mumbai Indians, played every single game, the empty seats did not keep up with the standards that the city's cricketing audience had set in the women's game. **Locals spoke of how festivals like Holi and Ramadan potentially contributed to thinner crowds this time.**

The cruel March humidity might have also played a part. Brabourne's open press box, while great for atmosphere, didn't give scribes the comfort of air conditioning or relief from sweat-drenched clothes on matchdays. The heat was so bad that a well-refrigerated bar of chocolate

